emblem of the seals of many Buddhist monastic establishments across India.[57] As one who trudged every path the Buddha is supposed to have walked, Ashoka could hardly not have come to Sarnath, the pillar and stupa strongly indicating he did. The pillar was brought here along an ancient channel which connected the Ganga river to Sarnath. This is how the monolithic railing made of Chunar sandstone which was recovered from the foundation of a later Gupta period shrine here, either in an unfinished or semi-finished state was also brought here.[58] It could have been erected around the top of a stupa or may have surrounded a tree or pillar. If it was on top of a stupa, it was likely to have been the stupa that Ashoka built. Known as the Dharmarajika, this building, enlarged six times after it was built (the last being in the twelfth century CE) was largely destroyed in the latter part of the eighteenth century. However, inside its core a sandstone box with a green marble relic casket was found containing gold leaves, decayed pearls, and a few human bone pieces. Could this have been one of the stupas that Ashoka built over the relics of the Buddha that he is supposed to have exhumed? No identifying inscription has been found.

The edict inscribed on the Sarnath pillar shows a new persona—a king opposed to divisions (‘samghabheda’) among monks and nuns:

> . . . the Samgha [cannot] be divided by any one.
>
> But indeed that monk or nun who shall break up the Samgha, should be caused to put on white robes and to reside in a non-residence.
>
> Thus this edict must be submitted both to the Samgha of monks and to the Samgha of nuns.
>
> Thus speaks Devanampriya:
>
> Let one copy of this (edict) remain with you deposited in (your) office; and deposit ye another copy of this very (edict) with the lay-worshippers.
>
> These lay-worshippers may come on every fast-day (posatha) in order to be inspired with confidence in this very edict; and invariably on every fast-day, every Mahamatra (will) come to the fast-day (service) in order to be inspired with confidence in this very edict and to understand (it).